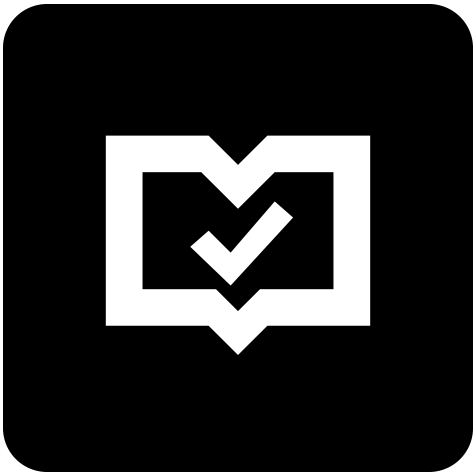


SOCCER · BOYS AND MEN · GRADES 9 TO 12 · SPORT PLAYBOOK

MEN'S SOCCER: THE WHOLE ROAD TO COLLEGE

What to do, when to do it, who pays, and what a coach is and is not allowed to tell you. Built from the 2026-27 NCAA rule text, the printed Division I recruiting calendar, the NAIA and junior college rule books, and the league structures a family is already paying into.

VERSION	RULES CHECKED	LEVELS COVERED
2026-27 · sample player: class of 2029	11 November 2026, against the NCAA rule text, the printed Division I calendar, the NAIA handbook and the NJCAA procedures chart	D1 · D2 · D3 · NAIA · junior college

> About 485,000 boys play high school soccer and 28,746 play it in the NCAA, which is 5.9 percent. In this sport the rule book decides when a coach may answer, and a 28-player roster limit decides how many of the boys already on a college roster can be joined by a new one. Both are free to know before a family pays $404 for a showcase day, fee included. That price is one seller's, not ours: $379 for two sessions and a $25 sign-up fee.

WHAT IS INSIDE

1. Read this first
2. How many players a team can take
3. The plan by date, class of 2029
4. What a coach may and may not do
5. Club, camps, and where he is seen
6. What to send, and what good video looks like
7. What the paperwork really means
8. What it costs, and what is wasted
9. Checklist by grade
10. Ten ways families get soccer wrong
11. Sources, and what we could not settle

This is education. It is not legal advice or school advice. It promises no result, no playing time, no acceptance, and no money. The NCAA Eligibility Center makes the final call on grades and on amateur status, and each school decides its own aid. Dates marked PROJECTED are worked out from the rule text, not printed by the NCAA yet. Chapter 3 lists them. Where this book could not find a rule or a price, Chapter 11 says so.

1. READ THIS FIRST

Read Chapter 2 before you spend any money. Then put the plan in Chapter 3 on one page and cross items off. The rest is for looking things up: what a coach may do, what to send, what the paper means, and what it costs.

THE MAIN IDEA

The rules are free. So are the dates, and so are the right questions. Most families never see them in one place. This book prints each rule with its bylaw number and the document it came from. Every one was read on 11 November 2026. Revision stamps are printed the way the rule book prints them: month, day, year. Where a rule could not be found, Chapter 11 says so. This book does not guess.

WHAT MAKES BOYS SOCCER DIFFERENT

- **The number that matters is a roster number.** A Division I school that opted in to the settlement may carry 28 players. The average Division I squad in 2024-25 was 33.5. Chapter 2 does the math.
- **A college tryout is not what it sounds like.** In Division I there is no tryout. A Division II school may hold one. Chapter 4 gives the tryout rule and the camp rule their own headings, because this is where soccer families get hurt.
- **The pro game sits next door.** A boy may train with a pro club before college, and may even play for one. He stays an amateur only if he takes no more than his real costs. Chapter 7 has the rule text.
- **He is not only up against his own class.** In one NCAA count, 18.5 percent of Division I men's soccer players had come from another four-year college. Chapter 2 lists who else holds the seats.

THREE RULES THAT SURPRISE FAMILIES

- **Before 15 June after 10th grade, a Division I coach may not send him recruiting messages.** That covers email, texts and mail, and calls are closed until the same day (Division I Bylaws 13.1.3.1 and 13.4.1). If he writes first, the school may send a short reply that explains the rule or points him at admissions (Bylaw 13.4.1.13). For the class of 2029 that day is 15 June 2027. The NCAA prints the rule and not the year, so this book worked the year out.
- **The old 9.9 is gone at schools that opted in, and it did not turn into a full scholarship for every player.** Those schools now have a roster limit of 28 and no NCAA cap on aid. Schools that did not opt in still live under 9.9. The College Sports Commission prints the list of schools that opted in for 2026-27. Look the school up there first. Some schools are listed for one sport only. Then ask the coach to confirm.
- **Division I has no National Letter of Intent any more.** The program ended on 9 October 2024. The paper is now a written offer of athletics aid. The rule book calls it an athletics aid agreement. The first day to sign is the second Wednesday in November of 12th grade (Division I Bylaw 13.02.13.1(f)).

HOW THIS BOOK DIFFERS FROM THE WOMEN'S SOCCER BOOK

The two books are sold side by side, and much of the road is shared. Both sports have the same Division I roster limit of 28, in the same table. This book's sources name four things that differ. One: the Division I calendar. The men's 2026-27 sheet prints two dead periods, 9 to 12 November and 11 to 14 December. The women's sheet prints four, and only the November one is the same. Two: the number of teams. The NCAA projects 823 men's teams for 2026-27 and 1,026 women's teams. Three: Division I Bylaw 12.2.1.2.5 is a men's soccer rule only. It covers costs paid by Major League Soccer for its showcase. Four: FIFA says its training compensation rule does "not apply to women's football." Where the sources name no difference, this book claims none.

WORDS THIS BOOK USES

WORD	WHAT IT MEANS HERE
EQUIVALENCY	A money ceiling the staff may cut into pieces. Division II men's soccer is 9.0. The old Division I number was 9.9.
COUNTER	In Division II, a player who gets athletics aid from the school. His share counts toward the 9.0.
ROSTER LIMIT	A cap on people, not money. It is 28 for Division I men's soccer at a school that opted in.
OPTED IN	A Division I school that takes part in the settlement. The official word is "participating." Schools in the conferences that were sued are in. Other schools chose.
TRYOUT	A workout where a player shows a college coach what he can do. The rule on it changes at every level. See Chapter 4.
DEAD PERIOD	Days when a coach may not meet or watch a player in person, on campus or off. No visits of either kind.
QUIET PERIOD	Days when a coach may meet a player in person only on the college's own campus.
OFFICIAL VISIT	A campus visit the college pays for.
UNOFFICIAL VISIT	A campus visit the family pays for.
AMATEUR	A player who is not paid to play. He may be paid back his real costs and no more.
REAL COSTS	This book's short form of the rule book's phrase, "actual and necessary expenses."
AID AGREEMENT	The written offer of athletics aid. In Division I it took the place of the letter of intent.
CORE-COURSE GPA	His grade point average in the NCAA's 16 core courses, on a 4.000 scale. The floor is 2.300 for Division I and 2.200 for Division II.
ELIGIBILITY CENTER	The NCAA office that certifies grades and amateur status for Division I and Division II.
HARD	A date that a document prints. Chapter 3 names the document.
PROJECTED	A date this book worked out from rule text. The NCAA has not printed it yet, so it can move.
SERVICE	A price from a seller's own page. It is one seller's price, not a rule.

Rule text: NCAA Division I Manual 2026-27 and the 2026-27 Division I recruiting calendar. Team counts: how many schools the NCAA expects to field a team, as of September 2026. All read 11 November 2026. Links are in Chapter 11.

2. HOW MANY PLAYERS A TEAM CAN TAKE

This chapter decides how many schools to write to and how much to spend. Two Division I numbers are in the air right now. One is old and one is new. Find out which one a school lives under before you weigh any offer.

LEVEL	WHAT THE RULE SAYS IN 2026-27	TEAMS	WHAT IT MEANS FOR A LIST
DIVISION I, OPTED IN	No NCAA cap on aid. A roster limit of 28 players (Bylaw 17.2). The school may give full or part aid to any player on that roster.	213	The scarce thing is a seat, not money.
DIVISION I, NOT OPTED IN	No NCAA roster limit. The school stays under the old aid limit of 9.9 equivalencies for the whole team.	(inside 213)	Ask the first question in Chapter 7. The answer changes the offer.
DIVISION II	9.0 equivalencies for the whole team (Bylaw 15.4.2.1.1). The rule caps the money, not the head count.	204	Most offers are a part, not a whole.
DIVISION III	No athletics aid at all (Bylaw 15.01.3).	406	The most teams of any level. No money here can be tied to soccer.
NAIA	The NAIA Official Handbook 2026-2027 has a table of upper limits for school aid. It reads "Soccer 12" (printed page 123, which is page 124 of the PDF file). That is a ceiling on the team's school aid, not a roster limit. Printed page 121 says no limit is placed on the number of players on a roster. The table prints no unit.	Not known	No recruiting calendar, and tryouts are allowed. See Chapter 4.
JUNIOR COLLEGE	24 letter of intent signees for the men's team. A signee is a player who signs the college's letter of intent. He counts against the 24 whether or not he ever receives aid. The women's team has its own 24. Division I may give full aid. Division II is held to tuition, fees, books and up to $250 in supplies. Division III gives none.	Not known	A two-year road. Ask which division the college is in for soccer.

Team counts are how many schools the NCAA expects to field a team in 2026-27. As of September 2026 that is 213, 204 and 406, which is 823. The NCAA's count of what was played in 2024-25 is 206, 211 and 410, which is 827. Both are official. They are different years and different methods. NAIA and junior college team counts were not found on an official page, so none is printed. Junior college figures are from the NJCAA Sports Procedures Chart for 2026-27. The chart is reissued during the year, so check the association's own page. All read 11 November 2026.

TWO DIVISION I NUMBERS. KNOW WHICH ONE BINDS YOU.

9.9 is the old Division I aid limit for men's soccer: 9.9 equivalencies, shared by the whole team. **28** is the new roster limit at a school that opted in, with the NCAA aid cap taken off. The table in Bylaw 17.2 reads "Men's Soccer 28." Its replacement rule, Bylaw 17.2.5, was revised on 1/16/26 and again on 9/10/26. The 28 did not change.

Which one binds your family today? It depends on the school. At a school that opted in, the 28 binds. At a school that did not, the 9.9 still binds, and the NCAA sets no roster limit there. The College Sports Commission prints the list of schools that opted in for 2026-27. Look the school up there first. Some schools are listed for one sport only. Then ask the coach to confirm.

One more figure is in print: 18.1. The College Sports Commission's table calls it the "potential increase in scholarships." It is 28 minus 9.9. It is room on paper. It is not a promise that any school will pay for it. A school that opted in has "the option" to give aid to every player. No rule says it must.

HOW THE 28 WORKS

- The school must turn in its roster by the day before its first game that counts toward the championship, or by 1 December. The earlier day wins (Bylaw 17.2.1, effective 7/1/25).
- After that day, only players on the list may take part in team activities (Bylaws 17.2.2 and 17.2.3).
- Any player who gets athletics aid or pay must be on the list. A boy on a small award takes one whole seat of the 28.
- The limit holds to the end of the school year or the end of the season. The later day wins (Bylaw 17.2.4).

DIVISION II: WHAT A COUNTER IS

A counter is a player who gets athletics aid from the school (Division II Bylaw 15.02.4). Each counter's aid is turned into a fraction. The top is the athletics aid he gets for tuition, fees, food and housing. The bottom is the value of a full award for him. A boy on half counts as one half. Add up every counter, and the team may not pass 9.0 (Bylaws 15.4.2.1.1 and 15.4.2.2). The average Division II squad was 39.0 players in 2024-25. Spread 9.0 over that many and the average share is under a quarter. That last line is this book's own arithmetic, not a rule.

HOW BIG SQUADS REALLY ARE

LEVEL	AVERAGE SQUAD, 2024-25	YEAR BEFORE	WHAT IT SHOWS
DIVISION I	33.5	32.5	Above the roster limit of 28. At a school that opted in, the list has to be shorter than it was.
DIVISION II	39.0	37.4	Far more players than 9.0 can pay for.
DIVISION III	33.2	32.3	No athletics aid, and a full squad anyway.
ALL THREE	34.8	33.6	The NCAA counted 28,746 players on 827 teams.

These figures are from an NCAA report on teams and players, updated 4 September 2025. They are on PDF pages 91 and 93, read 11 November 2026. The report counts anyone on the roster or squad list at any point in the year. So these run above a game-day squad.

WHO ELSE HOLDS THOSE SEATS

- **Transfers from four-year colleges.** They were 18.5 percent of Division I men's soccer players in the NCAA's 2020-21 count. Only men's basketball was higher, at 19.4 percent.
- **Transfers from two-year colleges.** They were 4.4 percent in the same count. Across all Division I men's sports the figure was 7.9 percent. The NCAA published both in July 2022. A newer figure sits on an NCAA dashboard that this book did not read.
- **Players from other countries.** The NCAA counted 269 first-year international players in Division I men's soccer in 2016, 341 in 2020 and 325 in 2021.
- **One researcher's count, not an official one.** A researcher sent a count to a US House committee in September 2026. It covers the 216 men's teams that reached the 2025 national tournaments. They had 7,183 players, and 43.2 percent were from other countries. The share was 50.5 percent in NCAA Division II. It was 70.7 percent in the NAIA. It was 61.5 percent in junior college Divisions I and II. Those are tournament teams, not all teams.

WHAT THE ODDS REALLY SAY

In 2024-25, 484,908 boys played soccer on a high school team. The NCAA counted 28,746 men's soccer players. That is 5.9 percent. By level it is 1.4 percent to Division I, 1.7 percent to Division II and 2.8 percent to Division III. The NCAA last updated these figures in March 2026.

Read that as a direction, not a promise. The NCAA calls its figures "approximations and not exact accounting." The high school number counts school teams only. Boys who play only club are left out. NAIA and junior college players are left out too. The NCAA says the true rate "could be lower in some sports." It prints no odds of going pro for men's soccer at all.

SO HOW LONG SHOULD HIS LIST BE?

This book's guidance, not a rule: build the list across all five levels, and count seats before you count names. Open the roster page of each school. Count the players. Count the seniors. Count the boys at his position. Then ask the coach how many he plans to add for 2029. It takes one evening, and it tells you more than any ranking.

3. THE PLAN BY DATE, CLASS OF 2029

He is in 10th grade this year, so every date below is real for him. Each row carries one of two words. The first row of the table explains them. The Division I calendars for 2027-28 and 2028-29 are not published yet. Check each date again inside six months of it.

WHEN	WHAT IS HAPPENING	WHAT YOUR FAMILY DOES
PROJECTED HARD	**How to read the first column.** HARD means a document prints that date, and the row names the document. PROJECTED means this book worked the date out from the rule text named in the row. No sheet prints it yet, so it can move.	
NOW HARD	Coaches at three levels may call, text and email him today. Division II: any time (Division II Bylaw 13.1.3.1). Division III: no limit on timing (Division III Bylaw 13.02.10.1). NAIA: its recruiting page says coaches and students "can communicate year-round." A Division I coach may not send him recruiting messages yet.	Write to schools at those three levels now. Do not read a Division I staff's silence as a no. The rule ties their hands until June.
NOW HARD	The NCAA's guide says to register with the Eligibility Center "before ninth grade." A Profile Page is free. The paid account for Division I or II shows $120 on the live screen and $110 in the NCAA's own checklist.	If he has no account, open the free page this week. Move to the paid one before his first Division I or II paid visit.
1 NOV 2026 HARD	The junior college letter of intent signing date for soccer this year. It is printed in the NJCAA Sports Procedures Chart for 2026-27. The chart is reissued during the year, so check the association's own page.	Nothing yet. It shows the pattern for his own senior fall. The chart for his year is not out.
9-12 NOV 2026 HARD	Division I dead period. The 2026-27 calendar prints it as "Monday through Thursday of the initial week for the fall signing date for athletics aid agreements." No meeting or watching in person, and no visits of either kind.	Nothing this year. Learn the pattern. The rule ties these four days to signing week.
11 NOV 2026 HARD	The fall signing date for this year's seniors in Division I and Division II. The NCAA's 2026-27 signing dates sheet prints it. The rule behind it is the second Wednesday in November (Division I Bylaw 13.02.13.1(f)).	Watch which older boys at his club sign, and where. Ask them what they sent and when.
2-13 DEC 2026 HARD	Major League Soccer's youth league holds its December event. Its spring cup runs 25 March to 2 April 2027. Both dates are from the league's own page, dated October 2026.	If his club plays in that league, these are travel weeks. If it does not, nothing.
11-14 DEC 2026 HARD	Division I dead period: Friday through Monday of the Division I men's soccer championship. A coach may still go to an event held with the championship, in its host city.	Nothing. Do not plan a campus visit for these days in any year until you have read that year's sheet.
23-25 DEC 2026 HARD	Division I quiet period. A coach may meet a player in person only on the college's own campus.	Nothing.

WHEN	WHAT IS HAPPENING	WHAT YOUR FAMILY DOES
PROJECTED **15 JUN 2027**	The first day a Division I coach may call him (Bylaw 13.1.3.1), and the first day a Division I school may email, text or mail him (Bylaw 13.4.1). Both rules say 15 June at the end of the sophomore year. On the same day a Division II coach may meet him in person (Division II Bylaw 13.1.1.1), hold one tryout on campus (13.8.2.1) and pay for a visit (13.3.1.2).	Send the full round that week: the email in Chapter 6, a reel, a full match and his grades. Have his Eligibility Center number in the email.
PROJECTED **END OF 10TH GRADE**	Division III coaches may now meet him off campus. The rule names no date. It says when he "has completed" his sophomore year (Division III Bylaw 13.1.1.1). His own school's last day sets it.	Tell Division III coaches on his list where he plays in June and July.
PROJECTED **1 AUG 2027**	Three Division I doors open on 1 August at the start of junior year. A coach may meet him off campus (Bylaw 13.1.1.1). A school may pay for a visit (13.6.2.1.1). He may make an unofficial visit that involves the soccer staff (13.7.1.1). A school gets seven recruiting chances with him a year, meetings and watching added together. From this day, no more than three off-campus meetings may be among the seven. Meetings during a paid visit, or during an unofficial visit under Bylaw 13.7.5, are not counted (13.1.5.1).	Before a paid visit, the school needs his transcript, his Eligibility Center sign-up, and his name on its request list (13.6.3). Plan the first trip around a match he is already playing.
PROJECTED **8-11 NOV 2027**	Division I dead period, if the NCAA keeps this year's wording: "Monday through Thursday of the initial week for the fall signing date for athletics aid agreements." The signing date is the second Wednesday in November (Bylaw 13.02.13.1(f)). The 2027-28 calendar is not published. The December dead period hangs on the championship dates, so this book cannot work it out.	Do not book a visit for these four days. Read the new sheet when it comes out.
PROJECTED **1 JAN 2028**	The first day a Division III school may pay for a visit. The rule says 1 January of his junior year (Division III Bylaw 13.6.1.1.1). One paid visit a school, and no longer than 48 hours (13.6.1.1 and 13.6.2).	Ask for one at each Division III school he is serious about.
BEFORE SENIOR YEAR **HARD**	The NCAA's guide prints the 10/7 rule for Division I. He needs 10 of his 16 core courses done before his seventh semester starts. Seven of the 10 must be in English, math and science.	Sit down with his counselor in the spring of junior year and count the courses.
SENIOR YEAR **HARD**	His athletics certification is asked for in senior year. The NCAA's sign-up screen says: "We will not begin your certification until it is requested by an NCAA school."	Ask each serious Division I or II school if it has made that request.

WHEN	WHAT IS HAPPENING	WHAT YOUR FAMILY DOES
PROJECTED 6-9 NOV 2028	Division I dead period, worked out from the same calendar wording and the same rule (Bylaw 13.02.13.1(f)). The 2028-29 calendar is not published. Division II has its own dead period: the 48 hours before 7 a.m. on the signing date (Division II Bylaws 13.02.10, 13.02.10.1.1 and 13.02.10.1.2).	No visits these days. Have the paper read by a parent before Wednesday.
PROJECTED WED 8 NOV 2028	The fall signing date for his class, if the rule holds: the second Wednesday in November, from 7 a.m. (Division I Bylaw 13.02.13.1(f); Division II Bylaw 13.02.10.1). It is the first day he may sign a written offer of athletics aid. The 2028-29 sheet is not out. This year's sheet says the last day to sign is set by each school's own policy. For junior college, this year's chart printed 1 November, and the chart for his year is not out.	Ask for the amount, the years and the date in one email in September 2028. No paper means no offer.

THE SEVEN DATES THIS BOOK WORKED OUT

None of these is printed by the NCAA for his class. Each is arithmetic from the rule next to it. The two November dead periods lean on two things at once. One is the second-Wednesday rule. The other is the 2026-27 sheet's own wording: "Monday through Thursday of the initial week for the fall signing date for athletics aid agreements." They are the ones most likely to move.

- 15 June 2027: Division I Bylaws 13.1.3.1 and 13.4.1; Division II Bylaws 13.1.1.1, 13.3.1.2 and 13.8.2.1.
- The last day of 10th grade: Division III Bylaw 13.1.1.1.
- 1 August 2027: Division I Bylaws 13.1.1.1, 13.6.2.1.1, 13.7.1.1 and 13.1.5.1.
- 8 to 11 November 2027: Division I Bylaw 13.02.13.1(f), and the wording on the 2026-27 Division I calendar.
- 1 January 2028: Division III Bylaw 13.6.1.1.1.
- 6 to 9 November 2028: the same two sources as November 2027, and Division II Bylaws 13.02.10, 13.02.10.1.1 and 13.02.10.1.2.
- Wednesday 8 November 2028: Division I Bylaw 13.02.13.1(f) and Division II Bylaw 13.02.10.1.

WHAT A MISSED DATE COSTS

A boy who has not signed up with the Eligibility Center may not take a Division I paid visit (Bylaw 13.6.3). A visit booked inside a dead period cannot happen. A boy who is short of 10 core courses before his seventh semester misses the Division I 10/7 rule, and no summer of soccer fixes that. Put the dates on one page and the page on the fridge.

Sources for this page: NCAA Division I, II and III Manuals 2026-27; the 2026-27 Division I recruiting calendar for other sports, updated 4 August 2026; the NCAA 2026-27 signing dates sheet; the NCAA guide for the college-bound student-athlete; the NAIA recruiting page; the NJCAA Sports Procedures Chart for 2026-27. All read 11 November 2026. Links are in Chapter 11.

4. WHAT A COACH MAY AND MAY NOT DO

Each level has its own rule book. A quiet coach is often just following his. Read the table first. Then read the tryout rule and the camp rule. Families lose money on those two.

LEVEL	CALLS, TEXTS, EMAIL, MAIL	MEETING HIM OFF CAMPUS	PAID VISIT	TRYOUT
DIVISION I	From 15 June after 10th grade (Bylaws 13.1.3.1 and 13.4.1).	From 1 August at the start of 11th grade (13.1.1.1).	From 1 August of junior year (13.6.2.1.1). One a school before 15 October after high school (13.6.2.2). No more than two consecutive nights, which means two in a row (13.6.4).	No tryout (13.11.1).
DIVISION II	Any time (13.1.3.1, effective 8/1/24).	From 15 June before 11th grade (13.1.1.1).	From 15 June before 11th grade (13.3.1.2). One a school (13.3.1.1). 48 hours at most (13.3.3).	One a school, on campus, from 15 June before 11th grade (13.8.2.1).
DIVISION III	Any time (13.02.10.1 and 13.4.1.1).	Once he has finished 10th grade (13.1.1.1).	From 1 January of 11th grade (13.6.1.1.1). One a school (13.6.1.1). 48 hours at most (13.6.2).	None. A coach may not run or watch a workout made to test him (13.11.2.1).
NAIA	All year, with no limit on how often or by what means.	No recruiting calendar.	No national start date or count was found.	Allowed for two days. Two NAIA pages disagree on what the two days cover.
JUNIOR COLLEGE	This book could not read the national contact rule at its source. Chapter 11 prints what is in circulation, with its label.			

Bylaw numbers in each row belong to that division's own 2026-27 manual. The NAIA row is from the NAIA's recruiting page. All read 11 November 2026. The Division I contact rules have no special case for soccer, so the general rule applies.

THE TRYOUT RULE, IN PLAIN WORDS

Division I: no tryout. A Division I college may not run a workout, a practice or a test where high school players show what they can do. That is Bylaw 13.11.1. Two narrow exceptions sit at 13.11.2 and 13.11.3, and this book did not read them in full. In practice, almost anything a coach organizes counts. The rule's own words are "any physical activity" at which prospects "reveal, demonstrate or display their athletics abilities."

So if someone sells you a "tryout" with a Division I staff, stop and ask what it is under the rules. It may be a camp, which is a different thing. It is not a tryout.

Division II: one tryout a school. It must be on the college's campus, or where the team normally practices or plays. It may be held from 15 June before 11th grade. He gets one at each school while he is in high school. A school may hold one more after it hires a new head coach (Division II Bylaw 13.8.2.1).

Division III: none. A coach may not "observe or conduct physical workouts" that are made to test a player (Division III Bylaw 13.11.2.1).

NAIA: two days, and the NAIA's own pages disagree. One NAIA page gives him "two days of try-outs at each NAIA member school," so two days a school. A second NAIA page, dated May 2026, says something else. So does the NAIA's

May 2026 guide. Their words are "a maximum of two days of tryouts throughout your entire athletic career." Both are official. Until the NAIA settles it, plan on the smaller one: two days in all. On a tryout visit the school may give him a bed and meals only if it would do the same for students who are not athletes.

THE CAMP RULE, IN PLAIN WORDS

A college's own camp is not a tryout. In Division I, camps and clinics sit under their own part of the rule book, Bylaw 13.12. This book read the title of that part. It did not read the text. So this book cannot tell you what a coach may say to him at a camp.

The rule book has a heading for phone calls about a college's own camp (13.1.3.1.13). It has headings for exceptions to the email rule, and one is tied to camps (13.4.1.10 to .12). Those were not read in full either. They show one thing for sure: the rule book treats a camp message as its own case. So do not read a camp flyer as a sign that he is being recruited.

One more piece of rule text helps. The match-day rule below stops a Division I coach from talking to him before he plays. That rule does not cover the college's own camp. It does cover a private camp that the college does not run (Bylaw 13.1.6.2.1). Division III puts camps, clinics and games-only events under its Bylaw 13.11.3, which this book did not read.

Before you pay for a camp, ask three things in writing. Which coaches will work with his group, by name? Is it the college's own camp? What is the refund rule?

MATCH DAY: WHY THE COACH WALKS PAST HIM

In all three NCAA divisions, a coach may not talk to him in person before he plays that day. In Division I the rule holds "at any site," and even when he is on a visit. The coach may talk to him once his games are done for the day and his own coach has let him go (Division I Bylaw 13.1.6.2.1).

Division II has the same idea. It also bars passing a note, or sending word through someone else (Division II Bylaw 13.1.4.1). Division III adds one more thing. A coach who is at his match, or who knows about it, may not text or message him at the site (Division III Bylaw 13.1.3.1). So a coach who walks past him before kickoff without a word is following the rule. Tell your son before the first whistle, not after.

HOW OFTEN A DIVISION I COACH MAY SEE HIM

Each Division I school gets seven recruiting chances with him a year. A chance is a meeting, or a time the coach watches him play. From 1 August of junior year, no more than three off-campus meetings may be among the seven. Meetings during a paid visit, or during an unofficial visit under Bylaw 13.7.5, are not counted (Bylaw 13.1.5.1).

"NO CONTACT DURING HIS HIGH SCHOOL SEASON"

Many families hear this as a rule. This book looked under every heading of Bylaw 13.1 in all three NCAA manuals. It found no rule that stops contact for the whole of his high school season. What exists is the match-day rule above. Whether he may play for his club during the high school season is a high school question. Ask your state association.

DEAD PERIODS AND QUIET PERIODS

Division I prints a calendar each year. The bylaw is 13.17. Since its 10/7/26 revision it points to the sheets on the NCAA's site. Division II and Division III have no calendar part for soccer in their manuals. Division II has one dead period: the 48 hours before 7 a.m. on the signing date (Division II Bylaw 13.02.10). The 2026-27 Division I men's soccer sheet prints three periods and no others.

- Dead period: 9 to 12 November.
- Dead period: 11 to 14 December.
- Quiet period: 23 to 25 December.

5. CLUB, CAMPS, AND WHERE HE IS SEEN

This is the thinnest chapter in the book, and it says so. The sources behind this edition hold rules and counts. They do not hold a study of where college coaches find boys. So this chapter prints what is on paper, names what is missing, and shows how to find the rest in ten minutes.

WHAT IS ON PAPER

- **The NCAA's odds leave club out.** Its high school number counts school teams only. Its own note reads "data from club teams not included." A boy who plays only club is not in the count at all.
- **One youth league prints its size.** Major League Soccer's youth league calls 2026-27 its seventh season and its largest. It lists more than 53,000 players, 2,743 teams and 310 clubs, with all 30 of the pro league's academies. A second source counts 318 clubs. Chapter 11 prints both.
- **The Olympic Development Program says who watches.** Its page says players "compete against the strongest players in their age group from other states and regions in front of college and professional scouts." Its steps are a state team, summer camps in four regions, and games between regions.
- **The rule book says when a coach may watch.** Division III has "no restrictions on the number or timing of evaluations" (Division III Bylaw 13.1.4). Division I gives each school seven recruiting chances a year with each player (Division I Bylaw 13.1.5.1). And no coach may speak to him before he plays that day. Chapter 4 has that rule.

Neither the youth league nor the Olympic Development Program is a requirement to get seen. No rule in this book asks for either one. A family with no club money is not shut out. The email, the roster count and the questions in this book cost nothing.

CLUB AND HIGH SCHOOL AT THE SAME TIME

No NCAA rule this book read limits a high school boy's amateur club soccer before he enrolls in college. Whether he may play club during the high school season is a high school rule. Ask your state association. Whether his club league lets him play for his school is the league's rule. This book did not read any league's rule on that. Ask the club director in writing.

The picture changes once he is on a Division I college team. In season, a college player who plays for an outside team loses his eligibility until it is given back (Bylaw 17.22.11.1.1). Out of season, a college may let no more than five of its players practice or play on an outside amateur team (Bylaw 17.22.11.1.2).

CAMPS: WHAT HE IS BUYING

A camp is a paid event. In Division I a tryout is not allowed, so a camp is not a tryout, whatever the flyer says. The camp rules sit in Bylaw 13.12, and this book did not read their text. Chapter 4 says what that means. This book sampled four price pages for one-day camps and showcase days. Chapter 8 prints them, tagged SERVICE.

WHAT THIS BOOK DOES NOT KNOW

- Which events college staffs go to. No source in this edition counts it.
- What a Division I overnight camp costs, or what a national showcase team charges. No page was sampled.
- What a club season costs. No club fee sheet was sampled, and no travel cost.
- How many NAIA and junior college men's teams there are. No official count was found.
- The rules of the other boys club leagues. No official page was read.

This book will not fill those holes with a guess. Chapter 11 lists what the next edition will add.

HOW TO FIND IT YOURSELF IN TEN MINUTES

1. **Open five roster pages.** Pick five colleges on his list. If a page lists each player's last club or school, write it down and tally it. That is where those five staffs found their players.
2. **Send the coach one question.** "Which events will your staff watch this year?" A coach can answer that in one line. A Division I coach may answer from 15 June after 10th grade.
3. **Open the camp's own sign-up page.** Write down the price, the hours, the ages, the coaches it names and the refund rule. If it names no coach, ask who will be there.
4. **Ask the club for its full-year fee sheet.** Ask for it in writing, with travel and event fees on it.
5. **Count the teams near you.** Go to the NAIA's own site and the junior college body's own site, and look for men's soccer. This book did not reach those pages, so it cannot tell you what they show.

Sources: NCAA estimated probability figures, last updated March 2026; the youth league's own schedule page, dated October 2026; the Olympic Development Program page; NCAA Division I and Division III Manuals 2026-27. All read 11 November 2026. Links and names are in Chapter 11.

6. WHAT TO SEND, AND WHAT GOOD VIDEO LOOKS LIKE

One email, from him, with links and no attachments. Keep it short. Put what a coach looks for in the first four lines. Say how each number was counted or measured.

SUBJECT LINE, 65 CHARACTERS, NOT COUNTING SPACES

2029 center back at Anytown South HS · 6'1" · 3.6 GPA · full match and reel inside

BODY, ABOUT 185 WORDS, FROM HIS OWN MAILBOX

Coach Halloway,

My name is Alex Nkemdi. I am a center back in the class of 2029 at Anytown South HS. My club team is Anytown United, under-17 boys. I play on the left side and I am left-footed.

This club season so far: 11 matches, 11 starts, 990 minutes. Our team gave up 8 goals in those 11 matches. I scored 2, both from corners.

Measured in June 2027 by my school trainer: 6'1" barefoot, 172 pounds.

Unweighted GPA 3.6 on a 4-point scale. NCAA ID 2907431866. I plan to major in biology.

I am writing because your team builds from the back. My club plays the same way. I have three questions, and each needs one line:
1. Is your team under the 28-player roster limit this year?
2. How many center backs do you plan to add for 2029?
3. What time zone are you in? I can take a call any weekday after 4 p.m. your time.

Reel, 3 minutes, no login: example.com/alex-reel
Full match, no login: example.com/alex-match
Club schedule: example.com/alex-schedule

Thank you for your time.

Alex Nkemdi
player@example.com · (555) 555-0163

Invented player, invented school, invented club and invented coach. Every number in the sample is made up to show the form, and the links are placeholders. Sample emails in this book name no real high school, club, league, camp or service.

WHY IT IS WRITTEN THIS WAY

- **He writes it.** It comes from his mailbox, in his words. A parent may check it. A parent should not send it.
- **Class, position and school in the subject.** A coach should know who this is before he opens it.
- **Numbers with a count behind them.** Two goals mean one thing in three matches and another in 11. Give matches, starts and minutes.
- **A measure with a date.** Say who measured him, in what month, and with shoes on or off.
- **His NCAA number.** A Division I school needs his Eligibility Center sign-up and his transcript before it may pay for a visit (Bylaw 13.6.3). Putting the number in the email saves a week.
- **The roster question.** The answer tells you if the school lives under the 28 or under the old 9.9. Chapter 2 says why that matters.
- **A time zone, not a town.** A Division I coach may call him from 15 June after 10th grade (Bylaw 13.1.3.1). To set a call, the two of them need the hour, not the address.
- **Sent on the right day.** Before 15 June after 10th grade, a Division I coach may not send him recruiting messages. If he writes first, the school may send a short reply that explains the rule or points him at admissions. Coaches in Division II, Division III and the NAIA may write back today.
- **Links that open.** Test each link on a phone that is signed out. If it asks for a login, fix it before he sends.

WHAT GOOD VIDEO LOOKS LIKE

No rule sets a standard for a soccer reel. No official body in this book's sources prints one, and this edition holds no coach's statement on video. So this part is this book's guidance, not a rule, and no document stands behind it. The best source is the coach. Ask him what he wants to see.

- Use match play, not drills.
- Use a wide shot, so the coach can see the players around him.
- Mark him for a second before each clip starts. Then let the play run.
- Start each clip a few seconds before he gets the ball, and end it a few seconds after he lets it go.
- Put his name, class, position, shirt number and shirt color on the first frame.
- Put his best clips first, and keep the reel short.
- Show both halves of his job: with the ball and without it.
- Keep one full match ready, and say which half he plays where.

POSITION	WHAT TO SHOW, AS GUIDANCE ONLY
GOALKEEPER	Saves, high balls, one-on-ones, and passing with feet and hands.
CENTER BACK	One-on-one defending, headers, and passing out from the back under pressure.
OUTSIDE BACK	One-on-one defending, runs to get back, and crosses.
MIDFIELDER	Taking the ball under pressure, passing short and long, and winning the ball back.
WINGER OR FORWARD	Runs off the ball, finishing with both feet, and taking on a defender.

WHAT THIS CHAPTER CANNOT TELL YOU

How long a college coach watches a reel. How many emails a staff gets. Which stats a staff trusts. This edition has no source for any of them, so it prints none. A line in his first email does more than any guide: "What would you like to see from me next?"

7. WHAT THE PAPERWORK REALLY MEANS

Four things decide this: an account, his grades, an offer, and his amateur status. Soccer puts the most weight on the last one, because a pro club may come to him before a college does.

THE ACCOUNT

ELIGIBILITY CENTER ACCOUNT	WHO IT IS FOR	PRICE
Academic and Athletics Certification	A boy who plans to play in Division I or Division II. He needs it before a paid visit at those levels.	$120 on the live sign-up screen. $110 in the NCAA's own checklist. For students from other countries, $180 and $170.
Athletics Certification	A student from another country who is going to Division III, or a transfer who needs only the athletics check.	$75 in the NCAA's checklist.
Profile Page	A boy headed to Division III, or not yet in high school, or not sure. It can be changed to a paid account later.	Free.

Two NCAA sources disagree on the price, so both are printed. The live screen is the later one, read on 11 November 2026. Fees are not paid back after 30 days. A student who qualifies may ask for a fee waiver. A walk-on is a player who joins with no athletics aid. He must register too.

The NAIA has its own Eligibility Center. Its May 2026 guide prints a one-time fee of $110 for students from US and Canadian high schools, and $170 for others.

THE GRADES

- **Division I.** 16 core courses, with a core-course GPA of at least 2.300 on a 4.000 scale. That includes four years of English and three of math at Algebra I or higher (Bylaw 14.3.1.1, revised 6/24/26). Ten of the 16 must be done before his seventh semester starts. Seven of those 10 must be in English, math and science.
- **Division II.** 16 core courses, a core-course GPA of at least 2.200, and proof that he graduated. An early path lists 14 core courses and a 2.500 (Division II Manual, Figure 14-1).
- **Division III.** The NCAA sets no core-course count. Each school sets its own bar.

THE OFFER

In Division I the paper is a written offer of athletics aid. The rule book's name for it is an athletics aid agreement (Bylaw 13.02.13). The National Letter of Intent ended for Division I on 9 October 2024. A guide that still says "letter of intent" about a Division I school is out of date.

- **When.** The fall signing date is the second Wednesday in November, from 7 a.m. This year the NCAA printed it as 11 November 2026. The last day to sign is set by each school's own policy. These dates do not apply to a player who transfers from a four-year college.
- **Division II.** The paper is an institutional athletics aid agreement. The first date is the same second Wednesday (Division II Bylaw 13.02.10.1).
- **Division III.** There is no athletics aid, so there is no aid agreement (Division III Bylaw 15.01.3).
- **NAIA.** There is no national letter. Some NAIA conferences make their members honor each other's letters. Ask the coach what his conference does.
- **Junior college.** The paper is still a Letter of Intent. He commits to the college, and the college commits to an amount of athletics aid. It covers one school year. A letter he has not signed goes dead 21 days after it is issued, and it may be issued again. Once he signs, staff at other NJCAA colleges may not contact him.

FIVE QUESTIONS TO ASK BEFORE HE SIGNS

1. Is your school under the 28-player roster limit this year, or under the old 9.9 aid limit?
2. How many players are on the roster today, and how many will be back?
3. What is the amount in dollars, and what does it cover?
4. Is this a written offer of athletics aid, and what is the first day he may sign it?
5. Has your school asked the Eligibility Center to certify him?

STAYING AN AMATEUR

FIFA and the NCAA draw almost the same line. FIFA says a professional has a written contract and "is paid more for his footballing activity than the expenses he effectively incurs." All other players are amateurs (FIFA transfer rules, Article 2). The NCAA says a team is professional if it gives any player more than "actual and necessary expenses," or if it calls itself professional (Division I Bylaw 12.02.7). This book calls those expenses his real costs.

BEFORE HE ENROLLS IN COLLEGE	WHAT THE DIVISION I RULE SAYS
A trial with a pro team	Allowed, if he takes no more than his real costs (Bylaw 12.2.1.1). The sentence sets no limit in hours. Once he is enrolled, each pro team may pay his costs for one 48-hour trial (12.2.1.2).
Playing on a pro team	Allowed, if he takes no more than his real costs (Bylaw 12.2.2.2.1). Once he is enrolled in college it is not allowed (12.2.2.2).
Signing something	He may not make "any kind of agreement to compete in professional athletics, either orally or in writing" (12.2.4). There is one exception before college. A deal to play on a pro team is allowed if it does not "guarantee or promise payment (at any time)" above his real costs (12.2.4.1).
Money from a pro club or academy	He may take up to his real costs for games, and for practice held to get ready for them, from a pro body that sponsors the event (12.1.2.2.3, revised 4/15/26). Prize money for where he finishes is allowed from the event's sponsor (12.1.2.4.1).
A pro draft	He may enter one once before college and once after he enrolls, as long as he is not drafted. After he enters in college, he has 72 hours to say he will return (12.2.3.2.6).
The men's soccer rule	He may take his real costs from Major League Soccer to go to its showcase, however long it runs. It does not count as a trial with a pro team (12.2.1.2.5, effective 8/1/24).

Who decides? The Eligibility Center does, one player at a time (Bylaw 12.1.1.1). A club's word that a deal is "college safe" is not a ruling. Before he signs anything with a pro club or its academy, get the pay line in writing and read it against the rows above.

- **Division III.** Before college he may take his real costs from a pro team for practice and games. He may not play for pay or take a promise of pay. A boy who enrolls on or after 1 August 2027 may be drafted (Division III Bylaws 12.1.4.1 and 12.1.4.2).
- **NAIA.** Its guide says he loses amateur standing by "signing a contract with any professional team."
- **Division II and junior college.** This book could not find the Division II sentence on pay and contracts before college. It did not open the junior college rule. Ask the school's rules office before he signs anything.
- **The clock.** Division I gives five years. They start at the earlier of two things: his first full-time term in college, or the school year after his 19th birthday (Bylaw 12.6). A gap year at an academy or abroad runs on the same clock.
- **Abroad.** FIFA bars a move to a club in another country before age 18, with a short list of exceptions (Article 19). The first is that his parents move there "for reasons not linked to football."

IF A PRO CLUB CALLS

The pro road is real in this sport, and it is narrow. Major League Soccer's 2026 draft had three rounds and a pool of 436 players from 150 schools. Its 2026 pay floor was $113,400 for a senior roster player and $88,025 for a reserve player, who must be 24 or younger. The league's page says there is no limit on the number of homegrown players a club may sign.

Two rule books meet at the draft, and this book could not settle how. The league says a drafted player who goes back to college "will not be draft-eligible in the future." The NCAA lets him enter a draft after he enrolls only if he is not drafted. Ask the college's rules office and the league before he puts his name in.

Sources: NCAA Division I, II and III Manuals 2026-27; the NCAA guide for the college-bound student-athlete; the NCAA registration pages; the NCAA 2026-27 signing dates sheet; the NAIA guide of May 2026; NJCAA letter of intent pages and the 2026-27 form; FIFA's player status and transfer rules, the edition that comes into force on 1 January 2027; Major League Soccer's roster rules as of 3 February 2026 and its 2026 draft rules. All read 11 November 2026. Links are in Chapter 11.

8. WHAT IT COSTS, AND WHAT IS WASTED

This chapter has fewer prices than it wants, and it says which ones are missing. What it does have is a list of things families pay for that the rules make pointless. Start there.

WHAT IS WASTED

- **A paid "tryout" with a Division I staff.** Division I may not hold one (Bylaw 13.11.1). You are buying a camp, or you are buying nothing.
- **A trip to meet a Division I coach before 1 August of 11th grade.** Before that day the soccer staff may not take part in his visit. That means no meeting, no team tour and no free ticket (Bylaw 13.7.1.1).
- **A trip inside a dead period.** No visits of either kind are allowed. This year's dead periods are 9 to 12 November and 11 to 14 December.
- **A camp bought as a way to "get recruited."** A flyer is not an offer. Chapter 4 says what this book could and could not read about camps.
- **A paid account bought too soon.** The Profile Page is free and can be changed later. The paid fee is not paid back after 30 days.
- **NAIA tryout days spent early.** One NAIA page says he gets two days for his whole career. Do not spend one on a school he would never go to.
- **A plan built on a full scholarship.** Division II has 9.0 to share, and its average squad was 39.0. Division III gives no athletics aid. A Division I school that opted in may give aid to all 28, and no rule says it must.

THE PRICES THIS BOOK HAS

WHAT	PRICE	WHOSE PRICE IT IS
NCAA Eligibility Center, paid account	$120 on the live screen. $110 in the checklist.	The NCAA, in two places that disagree.
NAIA Eligibility Center	$110, one time.	The NAIA's guide of May 2026.
One-day ID (identification) camp at one college	$95 at one college. $135 at another, which is $120 and $15 in fees.	SERVICE Two colleges' own camp pages.
Showcase day with many colleges	$199 to $289 for one three-hour session. $299 to $379 for two. A $25 fee is added to every sign-up.	SERVICE One private company's pages for seven cities.
Olympic Development Program, district training	$130 to $220, by birth year and by how early the family signs up.	SERVICE One state soccer body's fee table for 2026-27.

The SERVICE rows come from four sellers' own pages, read 11 November 2026. They are one sample, not a market. An ID camp is one day of drills and scrimmages a college runs so coaches can watch players in person, usually for a fee. The $95 camp ran from 9 a.m. to 3 p.m. for boys 14 to 19. The $135 camp was for boys 14 to 21. The top showcase price is $379 and the $25 fee, which makes $404. Travel, a bed and club fees are not in any of these numbers. Chapter 11 says where each price came from.

THE PRICES THIS BOOK DOES NOT HAVE

- A Division I overnight camp on campus.
- The fee for a national showcase team or an academy team.
- A full club season, with travel.
- What two travel weekends cost a family.

No page was sampled for any of the four, so no number is printed. Do not let anyone hand you a "typical" one. Use the ten-minute steps in Chapter 5, and write down the real prices for his own club and his own list. Chapter 11 says what the next edition will add.

WHAT THE COLLEGE PAYS FOR

VISIT	WHAT THE SCHOOL MAY PAY
DIVISION I, PAID VISIT	His travel at its real cost (Bylaw 13.5.2.1). A bed and meals for him and up to four family members (13.6.6), at no more than three meals a day (13.6.7.7). Up to $60 a person for entertainment (13.6.7.4). Up to five free tickets to a home game (13.6.7.2). No more than two consecutive nights (13.6.4).
DIVISION II, PAID VISIT	48 hours at most (13.3.3). A bed like the ones enrolled players get (13.3.5). Meals at cost for him and those who come with him (13.3.7). Free tickets to a campus game (13.3.6.2).
DIVISION III, PAID VISIT	48 hours at most (13.6.2). No more than three meals a day (13.6.5.6). Free general seats at a home game for him and those with him (13.6.5.2).
UNOFFICIAL VISIT	The family pays. A Division I school may give at most three free tickets to a home game and nothing else (13.7.3.1). Division II and Division III may give free tickets to a home game and nothing else (13.4.2.1 and 13.7.2.1).
NAIA TRYOUT VISIT	A bed and meals only if the school would give the same to students who are not athletes.

Each bylaw number belongs to that division's own 2026-27 manual, read 11 November 2026. The NAIA line is from the NAIA's recruiting page.

JUNIOR COLLEGE MONEY

The junior college body has three divisions, and a college picks one for each sport for four years. In Division I a full award may cover tuition, books, fees, room and board, and up to $250 in course supplies. It may also cover one trip a school year to the college and back. Division II is held to tuition, fees, books and up to $250 in supplies. Division III gives no athletics aid. Ask a junior college coach which division his soccer team is in before you talk about money.

WHAT IS FREE

The rule text. Every roster page. The Profile Page. The email in Chapter 6. The five questions in Chapter 7. A family that uses all five knows more than most families who pay for help.

9. CHECKLIST BY GRADE

One list for each year. He is in 10th grade now, so start there, and look back at 9th for anything not yet done. Each line names the chapter that has the rule.

9TH GRADE

- Open the free Profile Page at the Eligibility Center. The NCAA's guide says to register before ninth grade. (Chapter 7)
- Plan all 16 core courses with his counselor. That means four years of English and three of math at Algebra I or higher. (Chapter 7)
- Sign nothing with a pro club or its academy until a parent has read the pay line. (Chapter 7)
- Ask your state association if he may play club during the high school season. (Chapter 4)
- Start one folder for match video and one for report cards.

10TH GRADE: THIS YEAR

- Write to Division II, Division III and NAIA coaches now. They may write back today. (Chapter 3)
- Build his list across all five levels. Count the seats on each roster page. (Chapter 2)
- Do not pay for a "tryout" with a Division I staff. (Chapter 4)
- Ask the club for its full-year fee sheet, in writing. (Chapter 5)
- Get the email in Chapter 6 ready before June.
- Open the paid Eligibility Center account before his first paid visit. (Chapter 7)
- On 15 June 2027, send the full round. That date is worked out from the rule. (Chapter 3)

11TH GRADE

- From 1 August 2027, Division I coaches may meet him off campus and pay for a visit. That date is worked out from the rule. (Chapter 3)
- Send each Division I school his transcript before a paid visit. (Chapter 3)
- Tell him the match-day rule before his first big event. (Chapter 4)
- Use Division II tryouts with care: one at each school. Count his NAIA tryout days. (Chapter 4)
- Book no visit for 8 to 11 November 2027 until the new sheet is out. (Chapter 3)
- From 1 January 2028, ask Division III schools for a paid visit. (Chapter 3)
- Ask each coach the roster question: the 28, or the old 9.9? (Chapter 2)
- In the spring, count his core courses. He needs 10 done before senior year, seven of them in English, math and science. (Chapter 7)

12TH GRADE

- Ask each serious Division I or II school if it has asked the Eligibility Center to certify him. (Chapter 7)
- In September 2028, ask for the amount, what it covers and the signing date, in one email. (Chapter 3)
- Ask the five questions in Chapter 7 before he signs anything.
- Book no visit for 6 to 9 November 2028. (Chapter 3)
- The fall signing date for his class works out to Wednesday 8 November 2028. Read the 2028-29 sheet when the NCAA prints it. (Chapter 3)
- If the offer is from a junior college, sign inside 21 days or ask for a new letter. (Chapter 7)
- If a pro club calls, read the last box in Chapter 7 before he answers.
- Finish all 16 core courses and graduate.

THE ONE-PAGE VERSION

Know the roster number. Know the dates. Send one honest email. Ask for the paper. Sign nothing that pays him more than his real costs. Everything else in this book is detail for one of those five.

10. TEN WAYS FAMILIES GET SOCCER WRONG

Each one costs money or a year. Each one has a rule or a number behind it, in the chapter named at the end of the line.

1. **Paying for a Division I "tryout."** There is no tryout in Division I (Bylaw 13.11.1). It is a camp, or it is nothing. (Chapter 4)
2. **Quoting the wrong Division I number.** 9.9 is the old aid limit. 28 is the new roster limit at schools that opted in. They are not the same kind of number, and only one of them binds a given school. (Chapter 2)
3. **Reading 18.1 as money.** It is room on paper: 28 minus 9.9. No school has promised to fill it. (Chapter 2)
4. **Reading silence as a no.** Before 15 June after 10th grade, a Division I coach may not send him recruiting messages. If he writes first, the school may send a short reply that explains the rule or points him at admissions. (Chapters 1 and 3)
5. **Feeling snubbed on match day.** No NCAA coach may talk to him in person before he plays that day. (Chapter 4)
6. **Believing in a season-long ban.** This book found no NCAA rule that stops contact for his whole high school season. Club play in that season is a matter for your state association. (Chapter 4)
7. **Copying dates from the wrong sheet.** The women's soccer dates sit on the same NCAA sheet and are not the same. Last year's dates are not this year's. The sheets for 2027-28 and 2028-29 do not exist yet. (Chapter 3)
8. **Signing with a pro club without reading the pay line.** Real costs keep him an amateur. A promise of pay above them can end his college soccer before it starts. (Chapter 7)
9. **Looking only at Division I.** Division I is 213 of the NCAA's 823 projected men's teams. The NCAA puts the odds of reaching it at 1.4 percent. For all three divisions it is 5.9 percent. (Chapter 2)
10. **Waiting for a "letter of intent."** Division I ended it in 2024. The paper is a written offer of athletics aid. If there is no paper, there is no offer. (Chapter 7)

THE QUESTION THAT HEADS OFF MOST OF THESE

"Is your school under the 28-player roster limit this year, and how many players do you plan to add at my position for 2029?" A coach can answer it in one line. The answer tells you which rule the school lives under, and if there is a seat.

11. SOURCES, AND WHAT WE COULD NOT SETTLE

Every rule, number and date in this book came from one of the documents below, read on 11 November 2026. Where two official pages disagree, both figures are printed. Where a document was not read, this chapter says so.

NCAA Division I Manual 2026-27, page footers dated 11/11/26. Contact and visits: Bylaws 13.1.1.1, 13.1.3.1, 13.1.5.1, 13.1.6.2.1, 13.4.1, 13.4.1.13, 13.5.2.1, 13.6.2.1.1, 13.6.2.2, 13.6.3, 13.6.4, 13.6.6, 13.6.7.2, 13.6.7.4, 13.6.7.7, 13.7.1.1, 13.7.3.1 and 13.7.5. Tryouts: 13.11.1. Camps: the title of 13.12 only. Calendar pointer: 13.17, revised 10/7/26. Signing: 13.02.13 and 13.02.13.1(f). Amateur status: 12.02.7, 12.1.1.1, 12.1.2.2.3, 12.1.2.4.1, 12.2.1.1, 12.2.1.2, 12.2.1.2.5, 12.2.2.2, 12.2.3.2.6, 12.2.4 and 12.6. Core courses: 14.3.1.1. Roster limits: the table in 17.2, and 17.2.1, 17.2.2, 17.2.3, 17.2.4 and 17.2.5. Outside soccer teams: 17.22.11.1.1 and 17.22.11.1.2. web3.ncaa.org/lsdbi/reports/getReport/90008

NCAA Division II Manual 2026-27. Bylaws 13.02.2, 13.02.10, 13.1.1.1, 13.1.3.1, 13.1.4.1, 13.3.1.1, 13.3.1.2, 13.3.3, 13.3.5, 13.3.6.2, 13.3.7, 13.4.1, 13.4.2.1, 13.8.2.1, 14.02.19, 14.4.8, Figure 14-1, 15.02.4, 15.4.2.1.1 and 15.4.2.2. The 9.0 is also on the NCAA's Division II scholarships page. web3.ncaa.org/lsdbi/reports/getReport/90010

NCAA Division III Manual 2026-27. Bylaws 12.1.4.1, 12.1.4.2, 13.02.10.1, 13.1.1.1, 13.1.3.1, 13.1.4, 13.4.1.1, 13.6.1.1, 13.6.1.1.1, 13.6.2, 13.6.5.2, 13.6.5.6, 13.7.1, 13.7.2.1, 13.11.2.1, 13.11.3 and 15.01.3. web3.ncaa.org/lsdbi/reports/getReport/90011

"2026-27 NCAA Recruiting Calendar, Other Division I Sports," updated 4 August 2026, for the men's soccer dead periods of 9 to 12 November and 11 to 14 December and the quiet period of 23 to 25 December. It was read from an image of the page, because the file's text layer runs men's and women's soccer together. ncaaorg.s3.amazonaws.com/compliance/recruiting/calendar/2026-27/2026%E2%80%9327D1Rec_OtherRecruitingCalendar.pdf

NCAA signing dates for 2026-27: "All Other Division I and II Sports - November 11, 2026," with the final date set by each school's policy. athleticsaid.s3.amazonaws.com/2026-27DI_SigningDates.pdf

NCAA 2026-27 Guide for the College-Bound Student-Athlete, for "before ninth grade," the 10/7 rule and what the Eligibility Center certifies. fs.ncaa.org/Docs/eligibility_center/Student_Resources/CBSA.pdf

NCAA Eligibility Center fees, two readings. The checklist: $110, $170 and $75. fs.ncaa.org/Docs/eligibility_center/Student_Resources/Registration_Checklist.pdf The live screen on 11 November 2026: $120 and $180. web3.ncaa.org/ecwr3/register/CERTIFICATION Account types: ncaa.org/eligibility-center/register

College Sports Commission roster-limit table, "Soccer (M)": old limit 9.9, roster limit 28, potential increase 18.1, and the line that scholarship limits "have been removed" at participating schools. collegesportscommission.org/roster-limits

The College Sports Commission prints the list of schools that opted in for 2026-27. Look the school up there first. Some schools are listed for one sport only. Then ask the coach to confirm. collegesportscommission.org/participating-schools

Two facts were carried from this publisher's volleyball research and not re-opened for this book: that a school outside the settlement has no NCAA roster limit and keeps its 2024-25 aid ceiling (NCAA question-and-answer, May 2026), and that the National Letter of Intent ended for Division I on 9 October 2024. ncaa.org

NCAA projected sport sponsorship for 2026-27, as of September 2026, final on data to 29 July 2026: men's soccer 213, 204 and 406, total 823; women's soccer 349, 261 and 416, total 1,026. ncaa.org/sports/2013/11/20/composition-and-sport-sponsorship-of-the-ncaa-membership.aspx

NCAA Sports Sponsorship and Participation Rates Report, updated 4 September 2025, PDF pages 91 and 93, for 206, 211 and 410 teams, 6,901, 8,237 and 13,608 players, 28,746 in all, and every average squad size. ncaaorg.s3.amazonaws.com/research/sportpart/2025RES_SportsSponsorshipParticipationRatesReport.pdf

NCAA Research, estimated probability of competing in college athletics, last updated March 2026, for 484,908, 28,746, 5.9 percent, 1.4, 1.7 and 2.8 percent, and the note on men's soccer and the pros. ncaaorg.s3.amazonaws.com/research/pro_beyond/RES_ProbabilityBeyondHSFiguresMethod.pdf

NCAA Research, "Transfer Composition of Division I Teams," July 2022, for 4.4, 18.5, 19.4 and 7.9 percent in the 2020-21 count. ncaaorg.s3.amazonaws.com/research/transfers/RES_TransCompD1TeamsSlides.pdf

NCAA, trends in international student-athletes in Divisions I and II, December 2022, for 269, 341 and 325. Read from a search result, not the full file. ncaaorg.s3.amazonaws.com/research/demographics/2022RES_ISATrendsDivSprt.pdf

Written testimony of D. DePeppe to the US House Committee on Education and Workforce, September 2026, for 216 teams, 7,183 players and the four international shares. One researcher's count, read from a search result. edworkforce.house.gov/uploadedfiles/depeppe_written_testimony_9-16.pdf

NAIA Official Handbook 2026-2027, 41st edition, for "Soccer 12" on printed page 123, which is page 124 of the PDF file. The 12 is a ceiling on a team's school aid, not a roster limit: printed page 121 says "No limit will be placed on the number of student-athletes on any varsity roster." The recruiting and tryout rules, with their article and section numbers, are in the same handbook. naia.org/wp-content/uploads/2026-07-2026_Official_Handbook.pdf The recruiting page, for "no recruiting calendar" and two tryout days at each school. naia.org/why-naia/recruiting The page dated May 2026 and

the May 2026 guide, for two tryout days in a career and the $110 and $170 fees. naia.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/05/naia_guide_college_bound_student-1.pdf Letters of intent: interpretations.naia.org/implications-of-letters-of-intent

NJCAA Sports Procedures Chart for 2026-27, for 24 signees, the 1 November signing date and the three divisions' aid. The chart is reissued during the year, so check the association's own page. njcaa.org/compliance The letter of intent page, a release of 18 October 2013 and the 2026-27 form, for one year, 21 days and no contact after signing. njcaa.org/eligibility/loi The divisions page, read from a search result. njcaa.org/member_colleges/Divisional_Structure

FIFA Regulations on the Status and Transfer of Players, the edition approved 10 June 2026 that comes into force on 1 January 2027: Articles 2, 19 and 20. The edition in force on the day of reading was the one before it. digitalhub.fifa.com/asset/e495d04b-ef95-4d07-ace2-ea4d7781d7de/Regulations-on-the-Status-and-Transfer-of-Players_January-2027.pdf

Major League Soccer: roster rules as of 3 February 2026, for $113,400, $88,025 and homegrown players; the 2026 SuperDraft rules of 16 December 2025; the eligible list of 17 December 2025, for 436 players and 150 schools. Read from search results. mlssoccer.com/about/roster-rules-and-regulations

The youth league in Chapters 3 and 5 is MLS NEXT. Its page of October 2026 prints more than 53,000 players, 2,743 teams and 310 clubs, MLS NEXT Fest on 2 to 13 December 2026 and the Generation adidas Cup on 25 March to 2 April 2027. Read from a search result. mlssoccer.com/mlsnext/news/2026-27-mls-next-schedule-key-dates-to-know The second club count, 318, is a SERVICE figure from a parent site, spring 2026. ussoccerparent.com/mls-next-2026-27-new-clubs-and-conferences

The Olympic Development Program in Chapter 5 is run by US Youth Soccer. usyouthsoccer.org/olympic-development-program

SERVICE prices in Chapter 8, used here as one sample and not a shortlist. The $95 camp: one school's own page, read 11 November 2026. The $135 camp: one school's own page, read 11 November 2026. The showcase days: one private company's pages for seven cities. The district fee: one state soccer body's fee table for 2026-27. All four addresses are kept in the research log, not printed here.

WHAT WE COULD NOT SETTLE

Each line below is tagged UNCONFIRMED in this book's research, or is a place where two sources disagree.

- **His own calendar and his own signing date.** The 2027-28 and 2028-29 Division I sheets are not published. Each PROJECTED date in Chapter 3 is arithmetic, and each can move.
- **The camp rules.** Division I Bylaw 13.12 was read by title only. So were the exceptions at 13.11.2 and 13.11.3, and the camp headings at 13.1.3.1.13 and 13.4.1.10 to .12.
- **Social media messages.** Bylaw 13.4.1 says "electronic correspondence." The words "direct message" are not in the Division I Manual. The NCAA guide has a row for social media that was not copied out.
- **A season-long ban on contact.** None was found. Only the match-day rules exist.
- **The Eligibility Center fee.** $110 and $170 in the checklist. $120 and $180 on the live screen.
- **NAIA tryout days.** Two days at each school on one NAIA page. Two days in a career on another. The rule's own text is in the 2026-2027 handbook. This book has not yet printed which reading it backs.
- **Junior college contact and visits.** The national rule was not read at its source. One member college's 2026 paper quotes a paid visit from 1 June before junior year, one a year, 48 hours at most. A 2017 brochure says after junior year, two days and two nights. A SERVICE site says there is no recruiting calendar. Two-year bodies outside the NJCAA were not checked.
- **How many NAIA and junior college teams.** No official count was found. The one figure seen was a 2020 slide from one regional soccer body: 214 NAIA, and 160 and 81 in two junior college divisions. It is too old to print in Chapter 2.
- **Two team counts.** 827 NCAA men's teams in 2024-25. 823 projected for 2026-27. Both are official.
- **Two club counts.** 310 on the league's page. 318 on a parent site.
- **How many paid visits he may take in all.** No heading in Division I Bylaw 13.6.2 sets a total. The one limit read is one visit a school.
- **Amateur rules below Division I.** The Division II sentence on pay before college was not found. The junior college rule was not opened. The Division II and III rules on outside teams were not read.
- **Where the pro rules meet the college rules.** How the league's draft rule and NCAA Bylaw 12.2.3.2.6 work for one player. What the 11 amateur roster slots in MLS NEXT Pro pay. How FIFA training compensation lands on a US family. The second-tier pro leagues were not read at all.

- **Other gaps.** A newer two-year transfer share. A Division II roster limit. The rest of the Division II "60 total awards" sentence. What men's soccer graduates go on to do. Any change to the Division I roster number after 2026-27. The rules of other boys club leagues, and if an academy player may also play for his high school.

WHAT THE NEXT EDITION WILL FILL IN

- Prices for a Division I overnight camp, a national showcase team, a full club season and two travel weekends.
- NAIA and junior college team counts from an official page.
- Real roster pages for one region's men's teams, counted by level, for Chapter 2 and Chapter 5.
- The text of Division I Bylaw 13.12 on camps, and the camp exceptions to the phone and email rules.
- The 2027-28 Division I calendar, as soon as the NCAA prints it.
- What college coaches say on the record about video and email, for Chapter 6.
- The NAIA handbook's own words on tryout days, with the article and section number.

Made by The Commit Book. Education, not legal advice. No result, no playing time, no acceptance, and no money is promised. Rule text, calendars and price pages checked 11 November 2026. The player, school, club and coach in the sample email are invented.